

Given the use of multiple decks and reshuffling, it is still possible for a skilled player to get an edge in blackjack?

It was still possible through the 1990s. The movie *21* is an example of that. The MIT players on whom that movie was based actually just used my system.

The 10s-count system?

They used the complete point count, which counts high cards as -1 , low cards as $+1$, and divides by the total number of unseen cards.

Is that the best approach you came up with?

Yes. It is provable that the complete-point-count system is approximately the best possible system at an equivalent level of simplicity.⁸ The 10s-count system used to be about as good, but as the casinos went to multiple decks and reshuffling, the advantage of the complete point system began to grow. The rule of thumb is if they shuffle the deck halfway through, you can still win, but it is too much work, for too little money. If they shuffle two-thirds of the way through, that is just fine.

What was the first time you tried your blackjack system in a casino?

The first time was during spring vacation at MIT in 1961. I went with Kimmel, who was Mr. X in the book, and his friend Eddie Hand, who was Mr. Y in the book.

Did you know about their mob associations at the time?

No, Hand seemed like a rough type, but I thought that was just his gruff manner. Both of them were very wealthy. When I was in Kimmel's Manhattan apartment practicing before we went on our gambling trip to Reno and Tahoe, he complained that he lost \$1.5 million whenever it snowed in New York because he owned 64 parking lots in Manhattan. Hand owned a trucking business, which years later he sold to Ryder industries, and I know his warrants alone were worth \$47 million because I was following the warrant market at the time.

What was your experience on the first trip with them?

They wanted to put up \$100,000. I had a high degree of confidence in the theory, but I had never played for real money. I didn't know what